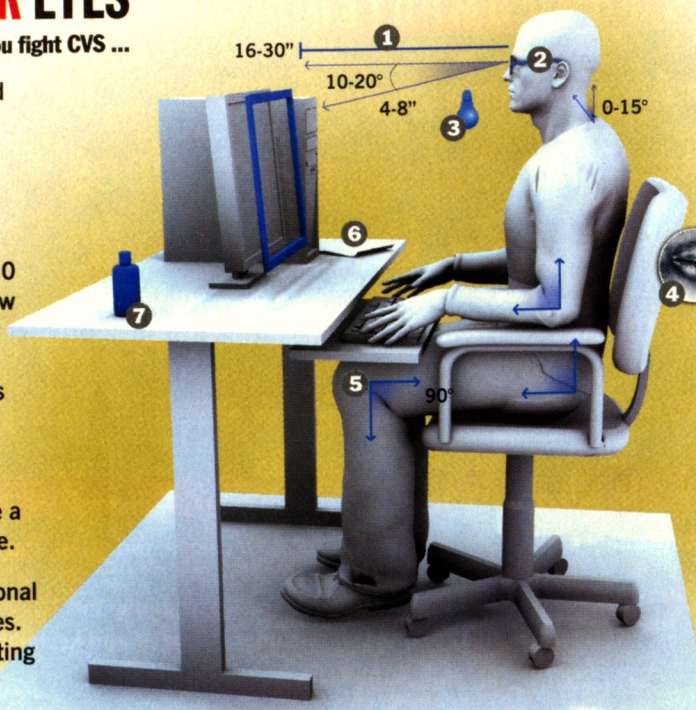


## SAVE YOUR EYES

Some tips to help you fight CVS ...

- 1 The monitor should be between 16 to 30 inches away from your eyes. Adjust the height, too. The top of the screen should be 10 to 20 degrees below eye level and the screen should be four to eight inches lower, so you are looking down toward it. Tilt up the screen slightly, like a book or a magazine.
- 2 Consider occupational or computer glasses. Anti-reflective coating helps.



- 3 Windows and light sources should be on the side of the monitor, so they don't shine in your eyes or reflect off the screen.
- 4 Blink rapidly and at least 10 times a minute.
- 5 Feet should be firmly on the ground. Hips, knees and arms should be straight and at right angles. Neck should not tilt beyond 0-15°.
- 6 Place documents on a copystand adjacent to the monitor.
- 7 Contact lens wearers should use artificial tears.

Graphics by RAM



### Drill for sore eyes...

**BLINK, BREATHE AND BREAK:** Look up for five seconds, pause and relax your eyes. Look down, pause and relax. Repeat five times. Blink. Repeat in each direction. Look up and slowly rotate eyeballs 10 times. Blink. Every 20 minutes, take a 20-second break and focus 20 ft away.

level, so you're looking slightly down towards it." Why? "Because, looking down covers more eye and so tear evaporation from exposed surface is less," he points out.

A real option is wearing special occupational or computer glasses during work. "When I put someone in a computer glass," says Dr D. Ramamurthy, medical director of The Eye Foundation in Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu, "it's going to be something that is simply designed to cut your workload by 25 to 30 per cent. So you're not focusing your eyes as much." Anti-reflective coated glasses have a tint to them to remove some of the glare from the screen. "The thing you don't want is for the computer monitor to be the brightest light in the room," says Ramamurthy.

"CVS strikes because we forget to blink in front of a computer," holds Dr Sanjay Dhawan, who heads the Lasik & Phacoemulsification unit at Max Eye Care in Delhi. "As a result, eyes stay open and dry out." A study in *Social Behaviour and Personality*, 2001,

shows that we blink 22 times a minute on an average when we talk; when we read, we blink 10 times a minute, but when we use a digital screen, this drops to seven times a minute. "That's why, rewetting drops are a good option, especially for contact lens wearers," he adds. The eyes are also exposed to 300 per cent more radiation than normal. "Place light sources at right angles to your computer, so they won't shine in your eyes or reflect on your screen," points out Dhawan, "If you have a glare problem, install a glare screen or a three-sided hood on your computer." A survey of 30 computer professionals in Udaipur, Rajasthan, in the November 2006 issue of the *Journal of Human Ecology*, found that 43 per cent had glare and reflections falling on the screen. No wonder, 90 per cent showed eye strain.

Meantime, the new-millennium disorder is churning out trendy slogans. One is, "Blink, Breathe and Break" (blinking 20 times a minute, breathing often to increase blood flow, and taking a break after 20 minutes of non-stop

computer work). There's also "the 20-20-20 rule": Every 20 minutes, take a 20-second break and focus on something 20 feet away. Yet another is "the RSVP rule" for detecting CVS: redness, secretions, vision change and pain. Yet as the *Indian Journal of Ophthalmology* survey reveals, the level of awareness among medics is woefully inadequate. Nearly 69 per cent had limited knowledge of occupational glasses and filters, while 24 per cent prescribed sedatives and anxiolytics irrationally.

Throughout history, there hasn't been any other age where humans would sit and stare at something for such prolonged periods of time as we do now. But nobody is going to give up their computer or Blackberry over stiff neck and red eyes. And why should they? CVS is a bit like spam. We may get the suffering we invite (in a wider karmic sense), but that does not stop it from being a pain. Yet, preventing CVS is just as simple as deleting spam from an e-mail inbox. Blink on it. ■